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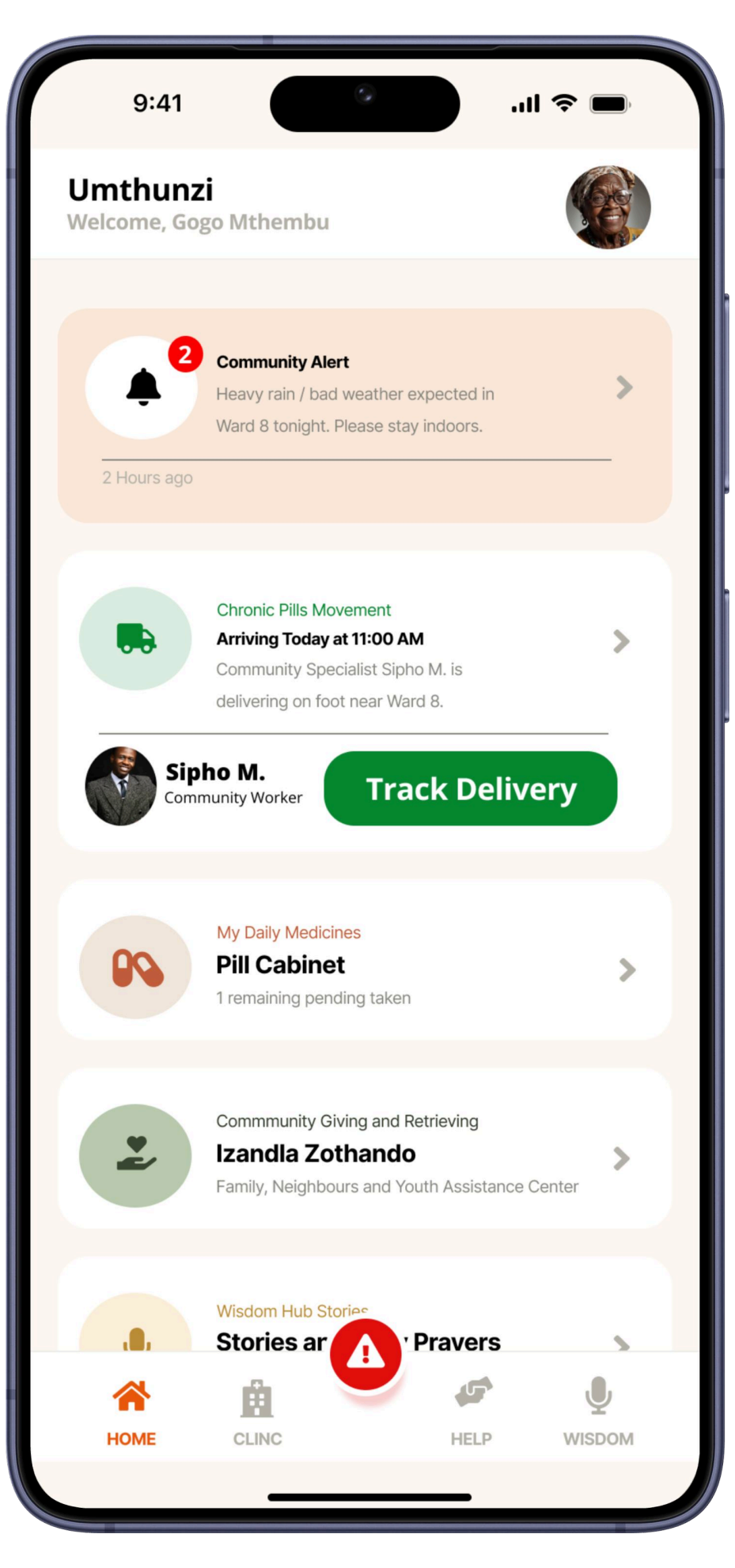
View Prototype

UMTHUNZI

The roof that protects.

Umthunzi was designed around the needs of elderly women living in rural communities who may experience difficulty accessing healthcare, remembering important health information, or requesting assistance when they need it. The goal was to create a simple, accessible and trustworthy digital experience that reduces complexity and allows users to manage essential information without feeling overwhelmed by technology.

Role	Duration	Tool
UX/UI Designer	8 Weeks	Figma



9:41

Umthunzi
Welcome, Gogo Mthembu

Community Alert
Heavy rain / bad weather expected in Ward 8 tonight. Please stay indoors.
2 Hours ago

Chronic Pills Movement
Arriving Today at 11:00 AM
Community Specialist Sipho M. is delivering on foot near Ward 8.
Sipho M.
Community Worker
Track Delivery

My Daily Medicines
Pill Cabinet
1 remaining pending taken

Community Giving and Retrieving
Izandla Zothando
Family, Neighbours and Youth Assistance Center

Wisdom Hub Stories
Stories and Prayers

HOME
CLINIC
HELP
WISDOM

Project Overview

A simple, high-trust mobile app designed to support rural Gogos by making it easier to track their health, access essential support, and stay connected to their communities. It addresses key challenges such as limited access to healthcare, difficulty managing health information, and barriers to requesting assistance. With features like simple health tracking, support requests, reminders, and community connections, Umthunzi promotes dignity, independence, trust, and accessible care.

The Design Journey

Empathize	Define	Ideate	Prototype	Test
Understanding the everyday needs, challenges and limitations of elderly rural users.	Identifying the key usability and accessibility problems affecting their experience.	Exploring simple solutions that prioritise clarity, dignity and ease of use.	Transforming ideas into accessible mobile interfaces and interaction flows.	Evaluating whether users could understand and complete important tasks confidently.

Empathy

Designing With Dignity

LIVE ON-CALL
MANAGING CHRONIC HYPERTENSION, HYPERTENSION, CHOLESTEROL, & ARTHRITIS

Umthunzi was designed with elderly users at the centre of the experience.

The research focused on understanding the challenges users may face when managing their health, remembering appointments or medication, and requesting assistance from family members or their community.

The experience needed to feel supportive rather than complicated.

This meant considering:
- Limited digital literacy
- Accessibility and readability
- Simple navigation
- Clear language
- Trust and privacy
- Easy access to assistance
- The importance of maintaining user dignity

Define

A Simpler Way to Stay Connected

The research highlighted a key problem:

Elderly users need access to important health and community-support services without having to navigate complicated digital systems.

The design therefore focused on creating an experience where the most important actions are immediately visible.

Simple (Reduce unnecessary steps.)

Accessible (Make information easy to read and understand.)

Trustworthy (Create an environment where users feel safe sharing information.)

Supportive (Make requesting assistance straightforward.)

Human (Ensure technology supports dignity rather than replacing human connection.)

User Persona

A Rural Gogo Who Wants Independence

MaNdlovu Dlamini

68 years old · Bushbuckridge, Mpumalanga

Caregiver · Grandmother · Samsung A-series smartphone

PRIMARY

HER VOICE

"I just want something simple. If I press the wrong button, I get scared I will break it."

DAILY ROUTINE
- 5am wake
- 6am prayer
- 7am grandchildren to school
- 9am household chores
- 1pm clinic or errands
- 6pm family dinner
- 8pm bed

ABOUT HER

MaNdlovu lives with her three grandchildren after her daughter passed away. She wakes at 5am, prepares breakfast, and walks 2km to collect water before 8am. She attends a local church and is known in her community as a trusted elder. Her son gifted her a smartphone two years ago but she mostly uses it for calls and WhatsApp voice notes.

TECH COMFORT

Low

Calls, WhatsApp voice notes, basic browsing only

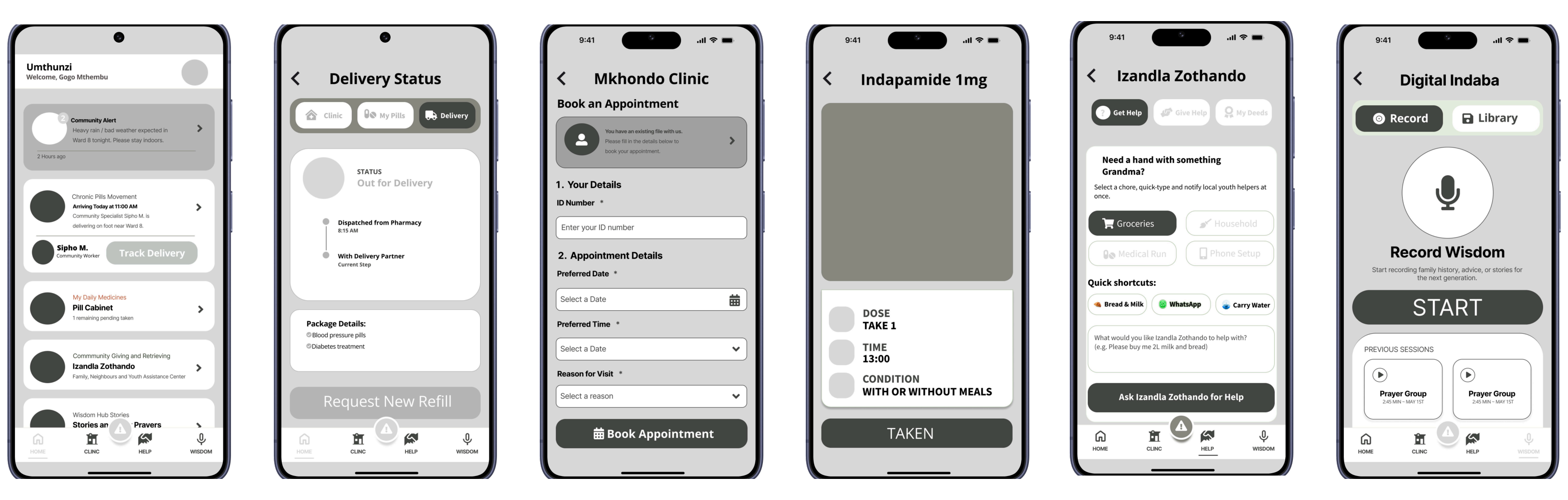
GOALS
- Never miss her blood pressure and diabetes medication
- Know when the clinic is open before making the trip
- Ask a neighbour or family member for help without feeling like a burden
- Stay connected to her prayer group and community

LANGUAGES

Siswati · Zulu · Basic English

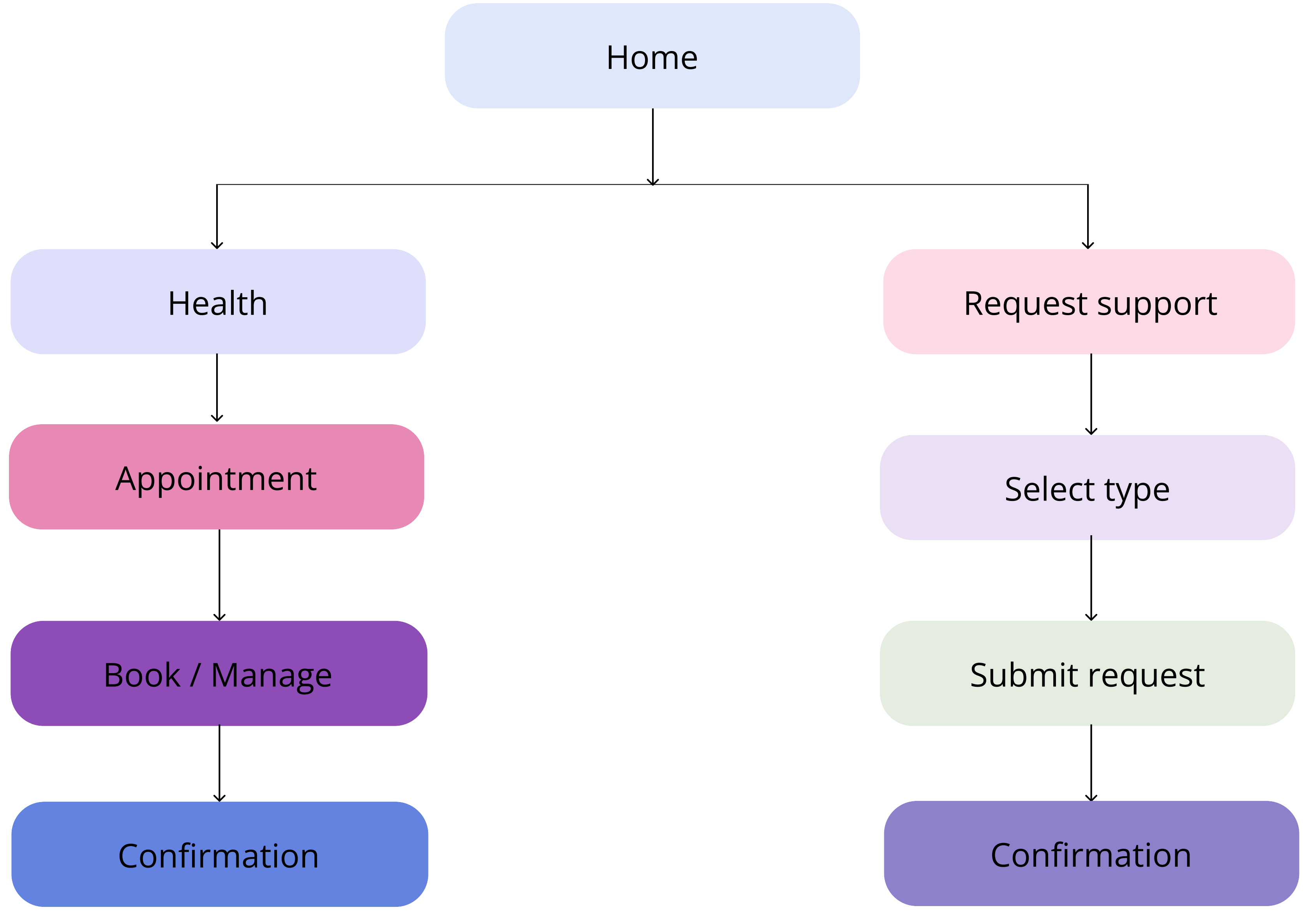
CHALLENGES
- Forgets medication when her routine is disrupted
- Small text and complex apps frustrate her quickly
- Has been targeted by phone scams before very wary of unknown numbers
- Limited data relies on WhatsApp and avoids heavy apps

Low- Fidelity Screens



Ideate

User Flow (Book an Appointment and Request Support.Journey)



Home

Health → Appointment → Book / Manage → Confirmation

Request support → Select type → Submit request → Confirmation

Test

Usability Testing

I conducted an unmoderated study with older adults in rural areas to understand how they navigate Umthunzi. The goal was to identify usability issues, points of confusion, and opportunities to build trust and independence.

Unmoderated study · **43 minutes** · **5 participants** · **Rural Areas**

What the community said during testing

"I could find my appointments quickly, but I wasn't sure how to reschedule one.

"The reminders are helpful, I don't forget my medication anymore.

"Asking for help felt safe, I liked that I could choose who sees my request.

"The app is easy to use, I like the big buttons.

From feedback to design

Improvement Recommendations

Increase text size and contrast throughout, so users with lower vision can read appointment details and medication names without zooming in.

Simplify navigation by reducing the number of cards on the home screen, so the most important actions stay visible without scrolling.

Add clearer labels to icons and buttons, pairing icons with plain-language text, so first-time smartphone users don't have to guess what a button does.

"The app is easy to use, I like the big buttons." Keep the large touch targets and simple layout, since they're already building trust.

What We learned

Key Takeaways

Design for dignity, not just accessibility. Making an interface usable for older, first-time smartphone users is only half the job it also has to make people feel capable, not managed. For Umthunzi, every large button and plain-language label needed to say "you can do this yourself," not just "this is easy."